real time. This section examines how autonomous combat and surveillance systems are reshaping tactics and strategy, the tactical and cost advantages they bring, and the profound ethical and legal questions their use raises for states and militaries worldwide (Duffield, 2015).

Table 8.1 illustrates the progressive evolution of UAV roles in military contexts, moving from early remotely piloted reconnaissance platforms to highly autonomous and swarm-enabled systems. While initial UAVs served primarily as observational assets with limited endurance and intelligence capabilities, subsequent generations incorporated *networked communication*, *precision strike functionality*, *and AI-supported tactical decision-making*. The most recent shift toward distributed autonomous operations marks a transformative phase in digital warfare, where drones not only act as *force multipliers* but also participate in cooperative mission execution with minimal human oversight.